



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

Ryan Fernando



FOR MORE
STORIES

Food for meditation and performance: Are we missing the link in today's fast food life?

Since gut health heavily influences athletes' performance and mental resilience, **nutrition plays a crucial role** in shaping their cognitive function, emotional state, and overall success.

As I counsel athletes on nutrition's impact on performance, it's evident to me on a daily basis that athletes' behaviour and discipline are significantly driven by their mental health. Healthy mental well-being requires focus on both the mind and the breath, the ability to recognise the calming of thoughts and flip the switch to mental grit.

So, when athletes come to me with whispers of anxiety, stress, or concerns about their mental well-being, I ask myself — 'are we failing to feed the athlete correctly?' Given that athletes must push both their physical and mental limits to achieve peak performance, significant attention must be diverted to training regimen, nutrition, and recovery. It becomes imperative to explore the intricate connection between diet, the gut microbiome (comprising all microorganisms in the digestive system), and mental well-being, especially in relation to anxiety.

The gut microbiome is a complex ecosystem of trillions of microorganisms present in the digestive tract, playing a crucial role in the connection between the brain

and the gut. The gut-brain axis, a bidirectional communication system between the gut and the central nervous system, is increasingly being recognised as a key player in this intricate relationship. Anxiety can become a silent adversary to the rigours of competition, training, and performance expectations, affecting an athlete's mental well-being and, consequently, their capacity for optimal performance.

Recent studies indicate that the composition of the gut microbiome can impact the production of neurotransmitters like serotonin and gamma-aminobutyric acid (GABA), essential in mood regulation and anxiety management.

In simple terms, your gut can calm you down if it's fed the right raw material. Fed the wrong kind of food, it may leave you less protected against mental stress.

Impact of Gut Microbiome on Athletic Performance

The diversity of the gut microbiome's composition could influence an athlete's energy metabolism, the recovery rate, and their susceptibility to injuries.

Athletes subject their bodies to intense physical stress on a regular

basis, leading to inflammation and muscle damage. Some studies suggest that maintaining a balanced and diverse gut microbiome may play a role in regulating inflammation, potentially expediting the recovery process and lowering the risk of injuries from overtraining.

Efficient nutrient absorption is paramount for athletes aiming to optimise their performance. The gut microbiome helps in breaking down and absorbing nutrients, including vitamins and minerals essential for muscle function, bone health, and overall well-being.

A healthy gut microbiome is closely linked to a robust immune system. For athletes, preserving immune function is essential to prevent illness and avoid disruptions to their training schedules. Research suggests that a well-balanced gut microbiome may contribute to a more resilient immune system.

Herbal Allies for Soothing Anxiety:

Tulsi (Holy Basil): Tulsi is a revered herb in India with adaptogenic properties and is known for its calming effects on the nervous system. You can consume tulsi tea or add fresh tulsi leaves to your diet.

Ashwagandha: Ashwagandha is